

Shostakovich and his family were evacuated to Kuibyshev, where he finished his Seventh Symphony, which he had begun in Leningrad. The siege dragged on and the symphony, seen as a symbol of resistance to the German oppressors, was given the title “Leningrad.” It was premiered in Kuibyshev in March 1942, and later that year given a moving performance in Leningrad by the few surviving members of the Leningrad Radio Orchestra, along with whatever musicians could be found in the city.

Shostakovich was expected to produce more patriotic music to boost morale. In 1943, now living in Moscow, he completed his Eighth Symphony, but far from uplifting, it depicted the dark aspects of war. The government first saw it as anti-Soviet, but put a positive spin on it by dubbing it the “Stalingrad” symphony, as if in honor of the fallen of the Battle of Stalingrad.

In the immediate postwar years, Shostakovich’s relationship with the authorities eased, although he reacted against the increase in anti-Semitism in Russia with works incorporating Jewish themes. But in general, he adopted a lighter, more conservative style of composition, and in 1947 was rewarded for his services by being made a deputy to the Supreme Soviet.

Humiliation and decline

However, the following year, in a reign of terror led by Andrei Zhdanov, chairman of the RSFSR Supreme Soviet, he and a number of his fellow composers were denounced for Formalism. He was dismissed from the Conservatory and forced to make a public apology. His humiliation was compounded when he was selected as a representative to the Cultural and Scientific